

Band-Aid

Few aspects of technology can ever aspire to be as frustrating as computing. Unavoidable that they are, PCs come with new problems for every one they solve, and some claim that PC problems can even drive people to drink! We've always hoped for a helping hand to turn to for every weird sound, every ugly error and every sluggishly-performed operation, lest we too succumb to such vices.

In this month's *Fast Track*, we've taken a long, hard look at the most common (and some bizarrely uncommon) problems that rear their ugly heads during the course of your computing experience. From upgrading and assembling troubles to trouble when online to problems with memory and hard disks, it's all here in this one-stop shop to cure what can ail your PC.

As always, this *Fast Track* has been written to be your happy helper—something that is thankfully within arm's reach. For quick reference and relief, there are Symptom > Problem > Solution structures within each chapter, so when something strange happens with your PC, your solution will be right there. You might also want to keep your eyes peeled for a handy tip every now and then.

The first two chapters will help you get your PC started without having to worry about beeps, clicks or any such undesirable sounds. Following them are solutions to common display and sound woes, both hardware and software, before we move on to more complex matters such as memory, storage and networking.

Unless otherwise specified, we've assumed that the OS you use is Windows XP, though many of the solutions aren't that different from those for older versions of Windows.